1: Imagination

Stepping Outside and Into Traffic

In 2023, the New York Metropolitan Area had the worst traffic in the United States, and the 20th worst in the entire world. It took New York drivers an average of almost 24 minutes to travel 6 miles—about four minutes faster than the worst city in continental North America (Toronto) but about three minutes slower than Washington, D.C., and about four slower than San Francisco.

One way to demonstrate how dramatic these differences can be is to compare how long it takes to get from two pairs of equidistant places in different parts of the United States. From Stony Brook University to the middle of Manhattan, as you can see from the below screencap of Google Maps, is a little over 60 miles. If we ask Google Maps to predict our commute by saying we'll leave SBU at 8 AM on a Friday, and ask it to take the most direct highway route possible, we can see that the estimate is somewhere between 90 and 150 minutes.

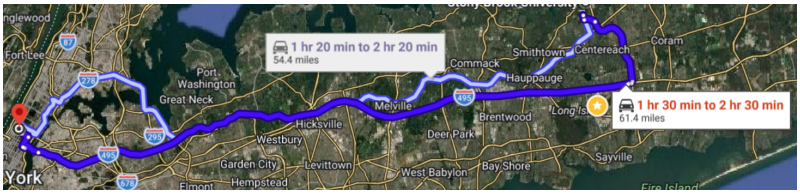


Figure 1: The Commute Time to Manhattan Predicted by Google Maps, 8 AM Departure, August 14th, 2026.

By contrast, consider another part of the country that is nearly the same distance (about 64 miles): between Topeka, KS and Kansas City.[1] As you can see below, this journey usually takes a little more than half the time. Why?

[1] This also follows the interstate, and departs at 8 AM on a Summer Friday.



Figure 2: The Commute from Topeka to Kansas City Predicted by Google Maps, 8 AM Departure, August 14th, 2026.

The next time you are sitting on Nicholls Road or 347, behind a heating-oil delivery truck but before you get to a lane-narrowing, and after someone just cut you off making an unprotected left just as the light turned green the intersection before,[2] you can ask yourself this question.

[2] I *hate* the Long-Island convention of turning left in front of traffic the moment a light turns green. This is illegal, and is called an "unprotected left." The New York State Drivers Manual Section 4266 (Right of Way) states: "If drivers approaching from opposite directions reach an intersection at about the same time, a driver that turns left must yield to traffic that moves straight or turns right…For any left turn, the law requires you to yield to any traffic headed toward you that is close enough to be a hazard." End of rant.

There are two basic kinds of answer. At the personal level, the answer to the question "why am I stuck in traffic?" leaves you with a simple answer: "because these jerks won't get off the road!" But the essence of sociology is to look *beyond* the personal to ask, in turn, why do all those other ~~jerks~~ people have to be on the road? It is, in other words, to expand our perspective from purely personal answers to questions of why things happen in the world to those that involve **social** causes and forces.

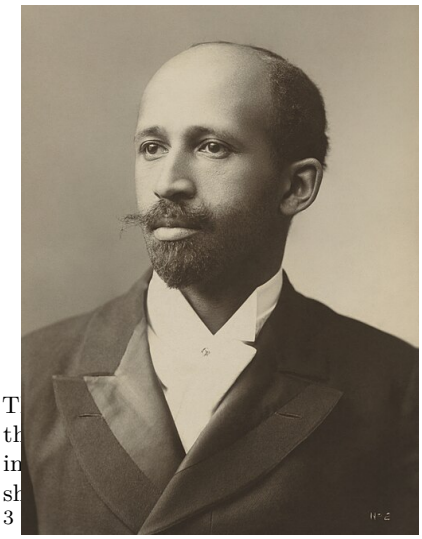
So, why are you sitting in traffic? On Long Island, there are lots of reasons, but a few of them are:

The **social** domain is any set of actions, interactions, beliefs, or material structures that draw from shared meanings or require coordinating people.

- Long Island has few, infrequent, and expensive public transit options, especially *within* the Island. Of the 15 counties assessed by the Center for Neighborhood Technology, Suffolk County has a 3.8 "overall transit score" compared to a 9.9 for New York City (on a 10-point scale.)
- `Pedestrians get killed a lot`
- `There are few sidwalks and bike lanes`
- `The island's suburban expansion was designed that way, by robert moses.`

- People are having to work more, and longer hours, and farther away from their workplace.

The Sociological Imagination



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The above example about traffic, and especially the moment of moving from a purely personal understanding of the causes of a given situation to its social components, is what we call the **sociological imagination**. Partly because of the intellectual structure of the discipline, sociologists tend to restate basic concepts repeatedly and in different vocabularies, and so there have been at least two major statements describing the sociological imagination.

One Phrasing: The Soul of Society

The first statement was made by W.E.B. DuBois (1868-1963),[3] who, in addition to being the first black man to earn a Ph.D. from Harvard, spent his notable career writing works exploring the legacies of slavery and race in the United States. He also wrote *The Souls of Black Folk*, which expressed his vision of the sociological imagination.

To get a sense of the point DuBois wants to make about the sociological imagination in *The Souls of Black Folk*, think back to when you were a child. Chances are that you will remember a time when other children or adults made you feel different. Maybe you were picked first or last for something; maybe people thought you were especially funny, serious, pretty, or ugly; maybe children wanted you to play certain kinds of games and not others; maybe your parents warned you about playing with other kinds of children; maybe they expected you to start working earlier or later than others.

Depending on how good your memory is, you might also remember the reasons that other people gave for treating you like they did. The reasons could have been idiosyncratic–you're too tall or short, or people loved or hated the haircut you chose–but if you heard the same reasons over and over, and across many

different people, the chances are that they represented **social categories** which formed the basis for how people perceived you.

DuBois recognized this dynamic too, and wrote about it in *The Souls of Black Folk* (2007), opening the book with his own painful childhood memory:

> I was a little thing, away up in the hills of New England...In a wee wooden schoolhouse, something put it into the boys' and girls' heads to buy gorgeous visiting-cards—-ten cents a package—-and exchange. The exchange was merry, till one girl, a tall newcomer, refused my card,—-refused it peremptorily, with a glance. Then it dawned upon me with a certain suddenness that I was different from the others; or like, mayhap, in heart and life and longing, but shut out from their world by a vast veil. I had thereafter no desire to tear down that veil, to creep through; I held all beyond it in common contempt, and lived above it in a region of blue sky and great wandering shadows. (Du Bois 2007:8.)

TODO: Introduce second sight and reflexivity; the former is a precursor to the latter.

A **social category** is a shared basis for grouping people together or dividing them apart. Social categories include gender, race, ethnicity, national origin, ability, appearance, and class.

W.E.B. DuBois was ambiguous about whether *anyone* could achieve second sight, but let's say that they can.

DuBois is making two points: first, that there *are* external forces affecting our experience based on who people perceive us to be, and second, that, if we cultivate it, we can bring those influence to the level of conscious awareness.

Another Phrasing: The Sociological Imagination

C. Wright Mills described the sociological imagination and its key constitutent concepts.

Sociological Imaginations: Climate Change

https://www.newsday.com/nextli/data/map-long-islands-stormy-future-cyh0ndzv

Sociological Imaginations: Opiod Addiction

https://www.kff.org/mental-health/alcohol-deaths-national-trends-and-variation-by-demographics-and-states/

Du Bois, W. E. B. 2007. *The Souls of Black Folk*. edited by B. H. Edwards. New York: Oxford University Press.